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Excluded Before Arrival: Labour Informality, Foreign Nationality, and Housing as a Barrier to Immigrant Integration in Chile

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Abstract

Housing access is a decisive but underexamined dimension of immigrant integration, shaping whether newcomers achieve belonging or remain confined to spatial and institutional margins. This study examines informal settlements (campamentos) in Chile, which have grown by 75.9% between 2017 and 2020, reaching 120,584 families by 2024–2025, of whom 39.3% are international migrants. Using logistic regression on the 2022 CASEN national survey, this research identifies labour informality and foreign nationality as the characteristics most strongly associated with residence in informal settlements. International migrants show odds of residing in informal settlements approximately twice those of Chilean nationals (OR = 2.06 for Latin American and 2.09 for other foreign nationals), and self-employment is associated with moderately but significantly higher odds relative to formal public-sector employment (OR = 1.49). Campamento residence is treated as an indicator of housing exclusion that may constrain broader integration processes, within a multidimensional integration framework. These associations are consistent with the operation of Chile's demand-side subsidy model, which conditions housing access on documented income and legal residency status, as a contributor to the exclusion of the populations that the integration policy is meant to serve. Region was modelled as a categorical factor, revealing substantial territorial heterogeneity independent of household characteristics, and a joint test of the interaction between occupational category and nationality was significant, suggesting that labour-market position and national origin may intersect rather than operate as fully independent axes of exclusion. The article argues that immigrant integration may be constrained while housing systems remain filtered through labour formality requirements, and proposes reforms—expanding subsidy eligibility, removing residency thresholds, and decentralising housing governance—as evidence-informed proposals aligned with SDG 8 (Decent Work and Economic Growth), SDG 10 (Reduced Inequalities), and SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities).

Keywords: immigrant integration; housing exclusion; informal settlements (campamentos); labour informality; foreign nationality; Chile; logistic regression; Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs); barriers to inclusion

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1. Introduction

Housing access is a decisive, yet frequently overlooked, dimension of immigrant integration: it determines whether formal legal status translates into substantive belonging, or whether newcomers remain confined to the spatial and institutional margins of the societies that receive them. For approximately three decades, Chilean housing policy was widely cited as an international reference. Multilateral organisations frequently cited the

country's demand-side subsidy programme as evidence that markets, with appropriate institutional design, could deliver affordable housing on a massive scale (Hidalgo 2002; Rodríguez and Sugranyes 2004; Vergara-Perucich et al. 2023). For a time, the headline figures appeared to support this claim as the housing deficit fell from 888,681 units in 1992 to approximately 450,000 by 2000 (Hidalgo Dattwyler 2007). What these reductions masked, however, was that the Chilean model focused primarily on tenure insecurity—namely, households lacking secure tenure—rather than on the structural, multidimensional factors that underpin housing instability, including the barriers that keep migrants and precarious workers outside the formal system altogether.

The window for deferring this diagnosis is now closing. Between 2017 and 2020, the number of households living in campamentos—the Chilean term for informal settlements, used throughout this article—rose by 75.9% (TECHO-Chile 2021). The most recent national register accounts for 1428 settlements housing 120,584 families, a 5.8% increase over the 2022–2023 figures (TECHO-Chile 2024). By any measure, these statistics are alarming. In practice, this is not merely a residual pocket of underdevelopment lingering on the fringes of an otherwise functional system; rather, it represents the visible manifestation of persistent failures in both housing provision and immigrant integration (Abufhele Milad 2023; Alegría-Corona 2024; Dohnke et al. 2015; Özler 2012).

Contemporary academic research on unauthorised dwellings in Chile concentrates heavily on cross-border population movements. Scholars consistently emphasise this demographic factor when analysing settlement proliferation (Alegría and Dovey 2024; Celhay and Gil 2020; Vergara-Perucich and Barramuño 2023). Such scholarly emphasis stems directly from the transformation of resident profiles within precarious zones over the previous decade (COES 2023; TECHO-Chile 2024). Investigators examine how foreign arrivals navigate exclusionary property markets that push them toward irregular encampments (Contreras et al. 2019; López-Morales et al. 2018). A parallel qualitative strand documents how multinational settlement communities organise collectively in response to that exclusion, drawing predominantly on the macrocampamento Los Arenales in Antofagasta, where Latin American migrant households form the majority (Arias-Loyola and Vergara-Perucich 2021; Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola 2019, 2025). National statistics further corroborate these spatial reconfigurations driven by recent migratory waves (INE and SERMIG 2023; SJM 2024). However, this emphasis on nationality, often fuelled by a rise in xenophobic sentiment, has obscured a more fundamental question: what labour conditions determine who is permitted to enter the formal housing system in the first place? In Chile, informal employment and the absence of a formal contract are risk factors at the very core of housing precariousness. Access to subsidies, mortgages, and even formal tenancy agreements may depend in practice on documented and reasonably stable income, depending on the programme or market segment[1]. When one factors in the slow creep of housing financialisation driving up prices, real wages that remain stagnant for much of the workforce, and a subsidy framework originally designed for "formal" citizens, the likely outcome is an expanding population of informally employed households and migrants displaced toward the urban periphery. The Chilean paradox lies in a sophisticated institutional apparatus that inadvertently reproduces exclusion, coexisting with an informal settlement sector that grows year after year and undermines the country's stated commitment to migrant integration.

This article argues that living in a campamento is rarely a matter of choice in any meaningful sense; it is a likely outcome for households excluded under constrained conditions, associated with the intersection of precarious labour, nationality-based barriers, and a subsidy system tailored to formally employed citizens. Utilising a logistic regression analysis of household data from the 2022 CASEN survey,[2] this study identifies the

socio-economic factors most strongly associated with residence in informal settlements, treating this residence as an indicator of housing exclusion that may constrain broader integration processes, rather than as a housing-market anomaly. In doing so, the analysis moves beyond simple supply-and-demand explanations that reduce the growth of these settlements to land scarcity or price pressure, and instead situates them within the broader policy and practice debate on how societies include—or exclude—newcomers.

From these findings, three contributions emerge for the study of immigrant integration. First, the study provides an empirically robust identification of the primary correlates of residence in informal settlements using nationally representative data, addressing the limitations of previous studies based on smaller or non-representative samples. Second, it situates the cross-sectional results alongside TECHO-Chile's aggregate temporal register evidence, documenting that the growth of campamentos has accelerated over the period observed, thus adding a temporal dimension that household-level regression alone cannot capture. Third, it moves from diagnosis to a concrete reform agenda for integration policy and practice, framed in alignment with the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

The article proceeds as follows. Section 2 reviews the literature and develops the theoretical framework; Section 3 contextualises Chilean housing policy and the growth of campamentos; Section 4 describes the data and methods; Section 5 reports the results; Section 6 discusses them; Section 7 concludes with policy implications and limitations.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

2.1. Global and Regional Perspectives on Housing Informality

Informal settlements across the Global South expand due to socio-economic inequality, governance gaps, and the limitations of housing programmes (Alene 2022; Baye et al. 2020). Although the discussion narrows to Latin America and Chile below, this opening literature is deliberately drawn from the wider Global South—including Ethiopia, Iran and comparative work across China, India and Brazil—because informal settlement growth is a shared structural process rather than a regional exception. As land prices rise, low-income households are structurally excluded from formal options, a pattern reinforced by weak municipal finances and poor inter-governmental coordination (Ren 2018). In Latin America, this is exacerbated by neoliberal housing regimes—prioritising credit-based ownership over public provision—and high labour informality (Contreras et al. 2019; Lonardoni and Bolay 2016). Volatile wages and limited social protections heighten precariousness (García et al. 2024). While some settlements offer proximity to employment and networks (Celhay and Gil 2020), they often entrench marginalisation, especially for migrant families (Hosseini et al. 2023; Lépore and Simpson Lapp 2018). When market-based provision replaces redistribution, exclusion rigidifies (Contreras et al. 2019). Labour and housing informality function as two sides of the same regulatory coin, withdrawing protection from those outside stable salaried work (García et al. 2024; Lonardoni and Bolay 2016). In Chile, where access to subsidies and mortgages requires documented income, this link is especially acute for the integration prospects of newly arrived populations.

Migration further exacerbates these pressures. Both internal and international migrants face prohibitive housing costs and discriminatory treatment within formal markets, often being concentrated in informal solutions as a result (Contreras et al. 2019; Rogerson 2018). The financialisation of housing has deepened urban inequality by transforming land and dwellings into speculative assets rather than social goods (Desai and Loftus 2013; Fields and Uffer 2016; Hidalgo Dattwyler et al. 2026). While internal migration drives informal urban growth where displacement meets weak governance and speculative land markets—typically rural-to-urban in much of the Global South, though inter-regional in already highly urbanised contexts such as Chile (Hosseini et al. 2023; Niva et al. 2019;

see Section 3)—international migrants face an additional layer of exclusion. Nationality requirements, residency thresholds, and documentation barriers may restrict them from both public programmes and private rental markets (Rogerson 2018). When those barriers close the formal channels, migrants look for spaces where they can wait. It is here that housing informality emerges as a salient indicator of housing exclusion that may constrain broader integration.

The Latin American trajectory is instructive. Neoliberal reforms transformed housing into a financial asset and pushed decommodified public provision to the margins (Nascimento Neto and Salinas Arreortúa 2020; Vergara-Perucich et al. 2022). Consequently, informal settlements have expanded steadily in peri-urban zones and redevelopment areas, where low-income households find themselves displaced by rising land values and exclusionary planning instruments (Yunda and Sletto 2017). Large-scale state interventions have failed to resolve this contradiction (Ren 2018). Two decades ago, the Economic Commission for Latin America and the Caribbean (ECLAC), known in Spanish as the Comisión Económica para América Latina y el Caribe (CEPAL), concluded that metropolitan growth in the region was outstripping the institutional capacity of housing systems, creating structural deficits that demand-side subsidies could never rectify alone (Rodríguez and Oviedo 2001). Price-to-income ratios have only worsened since. On the urban fringe, the informal settlement is often less a choice than the most realistic outcome remaining for those excluded from integration pathways (Helble et al. 2020; Yin et al. 2019).

2.2. The Chilean Context: From Subsidised Ownership to Spatial Exclusion

Chile occupies a distinctive position within this regional narrative. Its demand-side subsidy programme dramatically reduced campamento populations between the 1990s and the 2000s, and for years the country was upheld as proof that housing markets could flourish if the state intelligently subsidised demand (Hidalgo 2002; Rodríguez and Sugranyes 2004). However, this quantitative reduction masked qualitative and spatial issues that would eventually resurface in the form of new settlements and integration challenges on a different scale. Hidalgo Dattwyler (2007) coined the term precariópolis estatal (State-led Precariopolis) to describe the vast, peripheral social housing estates produced through state-subsidised programmes—estates defined by urban isolation, infrastructure deficits, absent services, and fractured social cohesion. The demand-side model generated housing units but failed to eliminate housing precariousness; rather, it relocated it. Rodríguez and Sugranyes (2004) captured this same outcome with the phrase "the crisis of those with a roof" (la crisis de los con techo): a crisis of people who have a home but remain trapped in spatial exclusion—far from the city, poorly connected, and cut off from work, public services, and prior social networks. The subsidiary solution had, in effect, traded the precariousness of the campamento for a different form of peri-urban isolation. Both terms are used hereafter without further gloss.

Hidalgo Dattwyler's (2019) subsequent work on social housing in Chile traces how the gradual shift in the welfare state—away from direct construction and towards demand-side subsidies—steadily narrowed eligibility criteria. Along the way, informally employed households, recent migrants, and the most vulnerable families were filtered out. This is precisely why informal settlements have persisted despite decades of housing programmes. Policies focused solely on the quantitative delivery of units have repeatedly neglected social and spatial integration. López-Morales et al. (2018) document the over-representation of immigrant households (particularly Latin American migrants) in Chilean campamentos, linking this to rental market discrimination and obstacles in accessing subsidies. Cortés-Urra et al. (2024) argue that the housing deficit remains concentrated among the structurally poor, whose irregular or informal incomes keep them outside any programme they might

wish to apply for. From this perspective, the informal settlement is a predictable by product. A housing model built around formal employment, documented citizenship, and mortgage credit is likely, sooner or later, to produce a residue that integration policy has been unable to absorb.

2.3. Theoretical Framework: Housing Exclusion Within a Multidimensional Concept of Integration

Immigrant integration is understood here as a multidimensional process. Ager and Strang's (2008) conceptual framework distinguishes economic, social, institutional, cultural and political dimensions of integration, with housing operating as a foundational domain that enables or constrains progress across the others. Accordingly, this article treats residence in a campamento as an indicator of housing exclusion that may constrain broader integration processes—not as a direct or complete measure of integration itself. To keep the argument precise, seven dimensions are distinguished: housing access (obtaining a dwelling through formal channels); housing stability (security of tenure over time); residential segregation (spatial concentration of groups); spatial exclusion (removal from centrality, services and urban life); social integration (participation in networks and institutions); institutional integration (access to programmes and legal recognition); and belonging (subjective and recognised membership). The empirical analysis speaks directly to housing access and, by extension, spatial exclusion; implications for social integration and belonging are interpretive and developed in the Discussion.

The theoretical lens is completed by Lefebvre's (1996) "Right to the City", which is not reducible to access to a housing unit in the abstract: it calls for access to urban life, centrality, and collective use-value—conditions aligned with integration understood as belonging.

On this basis, four hypotheses are formulated:

H1. *Informal employment is associated with higher odds of residence in informal settlements.*

H2. *Foreign nationality is associated with higher odds of residence in informal settlements.*

H3. *The association between foreign nationality and settlement residence varies according to labour-market formality.*

H4. *These associations vary across regions.*

3. Chilean Housing Policy Context and the Growth of Campamentos

The resurgence of informal settlements since 2010 has made visible, on a national scale, the limits of the demand-side model described above. As noted in the Introduction, eligibility for the main subsidy programme has been conditioned on documentation and income verifiability (D.S. N° 49, Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo 2011), and mortgage finance and formal rental contracts likewise tend to require documented income in practice, depending on the programme or market segment (Cortés-Urra et al. 2024). Households in informal employment or with recent migration trajectories are therefore disproportionately filtered out of formal channels.

Demographic shifts and spatial distribution define the current migration landscape in Chile. Over the ten years before the analysed survey, foreign arrivals surged. The CASEN wave reference period in December 2022 recorded 1,625,074 foreign-born residents. This digit represents roughly 8.2 percent of the total inhabitants, a significant jump from the 4.1 percent documented during the 2017 census (INE and SERMIG 2023). Just six countries make up 85.3 percent of these newcomers. Venezuela leads with 32.8 percent, followed by Peru at 15.4 percent, Colombia at 11.7 percent, Haiti at 11.4 percent, Bolivia at 9.1 percent, and Argentina at 4.9 percent (INE and SERMIG 2023). Between 2018 and 2022, the

Venezuelan demographic expanded by 55.6 percent (INE and SERMIG 2023). This same group faces the highest vulnerability regarding legal standing. They represent 65.9 percent of the 107,223 individuals lacking regular migratory status. Such an irregular condition inherently prevents fulfilling the previously mentioned Certificado de Permanencia Definitiva criteria. Spatially, these communities cluster in specific areas. The Metropolitan Region contains most of them. Meanwhile, Tarapacá, Antofagasta and Arica y Parinacota show the largest foreign-born shares relative to their local inhabitants, reaching 18.5 percent, 15.4 percent and 12.2 percent, respectively (CEP 2024). This distribution perfectly overlaps with territories where campamentos are predominantly inhabited by foreigners.

Economic integration for newcomers happens quickly yet remains restricted to a limited array of industries. Individuals born abroad predominantly find jobs in retail, culinary services, building projects, farming, household chores and basic roles. Such fields typically exhibit frequent staff changes, weak union presence and widespread lack of formal contracts (SJM 2024). Gender heavily dictates these occupational paths. Female migrants predominantly engage in household chores, caregiving and retail. Conversely, males mostly secure roles in building projects, transit and machinery handling (Garcés and García 2021). Unregistered work in these areas manifests via two pathways matching the occupational variables detailed in Section 5. These pathways involve waged jobs lacking written agreements and self-employed activities. Self-employment among foreigners stems from market needs alongside bureaucratic hurdles. Such hurdles encompass the lengthy processing of residency papers and the dismissal of overseas credentials. These obstacles block access to standard waged roles during the initial years post arrival (Acuña and Bravo 2025). This dynamic links the forthcoming occupational coefficients to the aforementioned paperwork prerequisites. Identical administrative conditions that postpone formal hiring simultaneously postpone entry into the housing subsidy programme.

Domestic population movements across Chile operate under distinct paradigms compared to the rural to urban shifts typical of the Global South. Given an urbanisation level nearing 88 percent, local mobility occurs primarily between regions and cities instead of countryside to city routes. Since the 1980s, the national export driven economic layout has shaped these patterns (INE 2020). Mainstream trajectories head towards zones focused on resource extraction and exports (Vergara-Perucich 2018). These include mining operations in Tarapacá, Antofagasta and Atacama, plus farming in O'Higgins and Maule, alongside aquaculture in Los Lagos. Historically, these areas sent people away, but relatively high industry payrols have transformed them into migration magnets. Meanwhile, the Metropolitan Region has seen its historical pull weaken somewhat (Rodríguez and González 2006; INE 2020). Within the northern mining territories, arriving populations focus on the extraction sites themselves. They also take up building and technical support roles serving those sites (Aroca and Atienza 2008). Subcontracting and informal hiring remain prevalent at the bottom of the pay scale within these specific industries.

Spatial dynamics are crucial here since domestic and cross-border movements target identical locations. Tarapacá, Antofagasta and Atacama draw both demographic streams. These same territories exhibit the sharpest campamento expansions and host foreign born majorities within their informal settlements. Newcomers of both types penetrate local property markets lacking saved capital and prior renting records, alongside the community ties that usually facilitate informal leasing. Simultaneously, they confront property expenses boosted by mining incomes that these newcomers rarely actually earn. Such conditions clarify why the statistical model yields elevated campamento living probabilities for recent domestic movers (OR = 1.34) alongside foreign citizens. The shared element between these cohorts is their fresh entry into a tight municipal property sector, rather than their specific national origin.

The expansion of campamentos in Chile has not followed a linear or smooth trajectory. Table 1 identifies three distinct phases: a period of gradual growth between 2007 and 2017, a rapid expansion between 2017 and 2022–2023, and continued, albeit slower, growth in 2024–2025. Crucially, the trend has never reversed. The data reveal sustained, cumulative pressure within a housing and integration system that has failed to absorb populations excluded from formal provision.

Table 1. Longitudinal trend of families in campamentos, Chile (TECHO-Chile registers).

Year	Settlements	Families	% Migrant Families	% Change in Families
2007	533	~27,000	n/a	—
2011	657	~35,000	n/a	29.6%
2017	822	46,423	~8%	32.6%
2020	969	81,643	~23%	75.9%
2021	1091	82,000	27%	0.4%
2022–2023	1290	113,887	33.5%	38.8%
2024–2025	1428	120,584	39.3%	5.8%

Source: TECHO-Chile Registers 2007–2025. Note: Figures prior to 2017 are estimates; post-2017 figures are derived from comprehensive national registers. The 2017–2020 change of 75.9% is calculated directly from the family counts reported in this table (81,643 − 46,423 = 35,220; 35,220/46,423 = 75.9%). n/a stands for a measurement that is not available for this study.

TECHO-Chile's national registers provide aggregate temporal evidence used to contextualise the cross-sectional CASEN analysis. They are successive aggregate counts rather than a household panel, and figures before 2017 are estimates while later figures derive from comprehensive national registers, so cross-edition comparisons should be read as indicative of trend. Households in campamentos grew by 75.9% between 2017 and 2020. By 2024–2025, 1428 settlements housed 120,584 families—a 5.8% increase from the previous 113,887 families and a 10.6% rise in the total number of settlements. Of these families, 39.3% are international migrants, up from 33.5% in 2022–2023. In absolute terms, this represents a 19.7% growth in migrant families (from 39,567 to 47,391). In the three regions where migrant households are most heavily concentrated within settlements—Tarapacá, the Metropolitan Region, and Antofagasta—migrants now constitute 63.6%, 61.5%, and 59.9% of the total campamento population, respectively (TECHO-Chile 2024). While this mirrors the broader geography of recent migration to Chile, it also reveals a more specific trend: migrants are disproportionately concentrated in campamentos, a pattern consistent with exclusionary barriers in other housing channels.

Geographically, the pattern remains uneven. Tarapacá, the Metropolitan Region, and Antofagasta show migrant majorities within their settlements, while the highest absolute concentrations of families are found in Viña del Mar, Alto Hospicio, Antofagasta, San Antonio, and Copiapó—a profile that corresponds closely to TECHO-Chile and Déficit Cero's (2024) "Major Migrant Settlements" typology, one of five distinct settlement profiles they identify, characterised by international migrant concentration in peripheral zones with severe infrastructure deficits and minimal access to public services. COES (2023) estimates Chile's total housing deficit at approximately 650,000 units, attributing the growth of campamentos to five structural factors: housing policy, the lived experience of urban exclusion, migration governance, gender, and environmental vulnerability. Taken together, the evidence resists a convenient interpretation: the expansion of campamentos in Chile is not a temporary anomaly but an ongoing structural process associated with labour informality, migrant exclusion, and the limits of a demand-side housing policy that fails to reach the households most exposed to both.

4. Materials and Methods

This study utilises the 2022 CASEN survey to estimate the socio-economic correlates of residence in campamentos in Chile. CASEN is the nation's primary socio-economic instrument, covering 202,231 households and providing granular data on income, employment, education, health, and housing. Its national scope makes it well-suited for analysing campamento residence—an outcome of low prevalence (2.07% of the sample) at a country-wide scale—though the "rare event" structure of the data necessitates specific methodological adjustments.

Given the binary nature of the dependent variable, logistic regression serves as the natural modelling framework. The objective is to estimate interpretable associations between household characteristics and the probability of residing in an informal settlement. Results are reported as odds ratios (OR), in accordance with standard practice for binary response models (Hosmer and Lemeshow 2000).

The unit of analysis is the household, classified by the self-reported head of household ("jefe/jefa de hogar", CASEN variable pco1_a). Employment, education, age, nationality and migration variables refer to the head; mixed households headed by a Chilean national are therefore classified as Chilean. To assess whether the reported associations reflect nationally representative patterns rather than within-sample associations alone, the model was re-estimated using svyglm() with CASEN's regional expansion factor (variable expr); results are reported below, alongside the unweighted specification.

The outcome variable is constructed from CASEN's v13 variable, which records housing occupancy status. Households in categories 10 and 11 (campamentos and precarious informal settlements) are assigned a value of 1; all others are assigned 0. Of the 202,231 households in the total sample, 4196 (2.07%) fall into the informal category. Both categories describe occupancy arrangements outside the formal tenure system recognised elsewhere in the variable; combining them maximises statistical power for a rare outcome. A sensitivity model separating the categories was not statistically stable, given the size of the smaller category, and was therefore not retained.

Labour informality was reconstructed from occupational category and contract status, rather than from an employment-status filter question. An earlier working specification used CASEN's o1 variable ("Did you work at least one hour last week?") as a proxy for informality; on review, this variable is a labour-force filter question, not a measure of informality, and its response categories do not distinguish formal from informal employment. The final specification instead combines o15 ("In your main job, do you work as . . .?") with o19 (written contract status), yielding nine mutually exclusive occupational categories: formal public-sector salaried employee (reference category), formal private-sector salaried employee with a written contract, private-sector salaried employee without or pending a written contract, self-employed, employer, domestic service worker, armed forces personnel, unpaid family worker, and not economically active (household heads who did not work in the reference week). This reconstruction increased the model's explanatory power substantially relative to the earlier specification (McFadden R^2 rose from 0.146 to 0.375), consistent with o15 $\times$ o19 capturing the intended construct more accurately than the filter question it replaced.

Explanatory variables are organised into five domains. Employment conditions are captured through the reconstructed occupational category described above. Education is included via years of schooling and highest level attained. Migratory status distinguishes internal migrants from non-migrants, whilst nationality differentiates Chilean citizens from Latin American and non-Latin American foreign nationals. Socio-economic standing is measured through NSE (socio-economic level[3]), poverty status, and income deciles. Finally, demographic controls encompass age, region, and overcrowding (defined as persons per

bedroom). Region was modelled as a categorical factor with 16 levels (Región Metropolitana as reference), rather than as a linear numeric scale, because Chilean administrative regions do not represent an ordered continuum; a likelihood ratio test confirmed that the categorical specification fits significantly better than a model without regional controls (Δdeviance = 1148.6, df = 15, $p < 0.001$), supporting H4.

One modelling decision warrants explicit mention: indicators of housing deprivation from the MPI-CASEN (Multidimensional Poverty Index)—including lack of basic services, structural condition, overcrowding, and habitability—were deliberately excluded. The MPI's categorical overcrowding indicator is a component of housing deprivation itself and was excluded to avoid definitional overlap with the outcome; "persons per bedroom", retained in the model, is a continuous demographic covariate describing household composition relative to dwelling size, treated as a control rather than a proximate indicator of settlement residence. Each excluded MPI item indexes a condition or consequence simultaneous with settlement residence. Their inclusion would have mechanically inflated the model fit whilst obscuring the structural factors associated with campamento residence long before such deprivations manifest.

Missing values were treated differently depending on their substantive origin, following inspection of CASEN's questionnaire flow logic. Variables whose missingness reflects a genuine skip pattern—values that are structurally "not applicable" because a preceding filter question routes respondents away from them (migratory origin, 53.3% missing; highest educational level attained, 26.3% missing)—were coded as an explicit "not applicable" category rather than merged with the substantive reference level, to avoid conflating a distinct population with the reference group. Variables with a trivial rate of genuine missingness (poverty status and income decile, both 0.06%) were recoded to zero, consistent with the survey's own treatment of non-applicable multidimensional-poverty items. Categorical variables (socio-economic level, occupational category, education, migratory origin, and nationality) were converted into factors. The sample was then partitioned into a training set (80%) and a test set (20%) using stratified sampling with a fixed seed (seed = 123) to ensure the proportion of informal households remained consistent across both sets.

Model performance is evaluated using McFadden's R-squared, the Akaike Information Criterion (AIC), and a confusion matrix applied to the test set. Given the rare event structure of the outcome (2.07%), the default classification threshold of 0.5 proved effectively redundant. Following King and Zeng's (2001) diagnosis of the rare-events problem, the classification threshold is treated as a decision distinct from estimation-bias correction: lowering the threshold from 0.50 to 0.05 affects only how predicted probabilities are classified for evaluation and does not correct rare-events estimation bias (e.g., Firth's penalised likelihood), which was not applied and is noted as a limitation. The model's aim is the identification of correlates of settlement residence, not out-of-sample prediction or formal classification. Variance inflation factors (VIF) were computed for the final model to assess multicollinearity; all values were below acceptable thresholds ($GVIF^{(1/2 \cdot df)} < 2.3$ for all covariates), indicating no problematic collinearity among predictors. All analyses were conducted in R (version 4.5.0) using the glm(), svyglm(), caret, car, and haven packages.

5. Results

5.1. Logistic Regression Results

Table 2 reports the logistic regression estimates based on the training sample. The McFadden R-squared is 0.375 and the AIC is 20,530.7, a substantial improvement in fit over the earlier specification ($R^2 = 0.146$) attributable to the corrected occupational-category variable described in Section 4. H1 and H2 are supported by the coefficients below. H4

is supported: region, entered as a categorical factor, is jointly significant (likelihood ratio test, Δdeviance = 1148.6, df = 15, $p < 0.001$). H3 receives qualified support. An interaction term between occupational category and nationality improves model fit relative to the model without interaction (likelihood ratio test, Δdeviance = 26.75, df = 16, $p = 0.044$), but no individual interaction coefficient reaches significance. The joint test therefore indicates that the association between labour-market position and campamento residence varies modestly across nationality groups, while the data do not identify which specific occupational contrasts drive that variation. This is read as suggestive evidence that these axes intersect, without locating precisely where the interaction operates.

Table 2. Logistic regression results: predictors of informal settlement residence, Chile (CASEN 2022).

Variable	OR	95% CI	*p*	Sig.
Occupational category (ref.: formal public-sector salaried)				
Formal private-sector salaried (with contract)	1.18	0.93–1.50	0.176	
Informal private-sector salaried (no/pending contract)	1.09	0.82–1.46	0.559	
Self-employed	1.49	1.17–1.90	0.001	**
Employer	1.06	0.71–1.59	0.767	
Domestic service	0.70	0.45–1.10	0.119	
Armed forces	0.50	0.12–2.05	0.332	
Unpaid family worker	0.65	0.25–1.70	0.380	
Not economically active	0.93	0.73–1.17	0.519	
Nationality (ref.: Chilean)				
Foreign national (Other)	2.09	1.84–2.38	<0.001	***
Foreign national (Latin American)	2.06	1.45–2.93	<0.001	***
Education				
Years of schooling	0.90	0.88–0.92	<0.001	***
Socio-economic level (ref.: E, lowest)				
D	0.28	0.25–0.32	<0.001	***
C3	0.05	0.03–0.08	<0.001	***
C2	0.50	0.46–0.58	<0.001	***
C1a	0.68	0.31–1.50	0.336	
ABC1	0.24	0.18–0.31	<0.001	***
Income and poverty				
Poverty status (higher = less poor)	0.34	0.31–0.36	<0.001	***
National income decile	1.05	1.02–1.08	0.003	**
Migration (ref.: no residential change)				
Internal migrant (from other region)	1.34	1.14–1.58	<0.001	***
Migration status not applicable	1.35	1.19–1.54	<0.001	***
Demographics				
Age	0.98	0.98–0.99	<0.001	***
Overcrowding (persons per bedroom)	1.01	0.99–1.04	0.407	
Region (ref.: Región Metropolitana; 15 additional levels)	Jointly significant, LRT $p < 0.001$			

Note: Training sample; McFadden $R^2 = 0.375$; AIC = 20,530.7. Region coefficients (15 levels) are reported in Table A1 rather than in the main table for conciseness; the joint likelihood ratio test confirms significant regional heterogeneity (Δdeviance = 1148.6, df = 15, $p < 0.001$). The Sig. column follows conventional thresholds (*** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$) as a visual aid; exact *p*-values are reported in the adjacent column.

Self-employment is associated with markedly higher odds of campamento residence relative to formal public-sector salaried employment (the reference category), consistent with the broader pattern that non-salaried and non-contractual work arrangements carry the highest exposure to informal housing. Households whose head is self-employed are associated with higher odds (OR = 1.49, 95% CI: 1.17–1.90, $p = 0.001$) than those with a formal public-sector job.

Foreign nationality emerges as a strong correlate, directly bearing on integration outcomes. Non-Latin American foreign nationals are associated with 2.09 times higher odds of settlement residence than Chilean nationals (95% CI: 1.84–2.38, $p < 0.001$), while Latin American migrants are associated with 2.06 times higher odds (95% CI: 1.45–2.93, $p < 0.001$). Internal migration is associated in the same direction: households whose head moved from another Chilean region within the previous five years show higher odds of campamento residence than those with no residential change (OR = 1.34, 95% CI: 1.14–1.58, $p < 0.001$). This reverses the negative association reported under the earlier misspecified occupational variable and indicates that recent residential mobility—internal as well as international—is associated with greater exposure to informal housing. Households for whom migration status is not applicable show a similar association (OR = 1.35, $p < 0.001$); this category should be read as a reference-category artefact of the explicit "not applicable" coding described in Section 4 rather than as a substantive finding.

Socio-economic coefficients display a sharp gradient. Using stratum E (the lowest) as the reference category, every higher stratum shows lower odds, with the most economically vulnerable groups showing the strongest association with settlement residence. Reduced poverty severity is associated with lower odds of settlement residence (OR = 0.34, $p < 0.001$), and each additional year of schooling is associated with lower odds (OR = 0.90, 95% CI: 0.88–0.92, $p < 0.001$). Overcrowding shows no significant association once occupational category and region are included (OR = 1.01, $p = 0.41$), with a magnitude and significance level considerably smaller than the effects of occupational category, nationality, or socio-economic standing.

5.2. Model Performance and Classification

With the classification threshold adjusted to 0.05, balanced accuracy reached 0.716. Because caret's confusionMatrix() function assigns the positive class by default to the majority category (non-campamento), performance metrics are reported explicitly disaggregated by class to avoid the ambiguity that this convention can introduce: recall for non-campamento households was 93.1%, recall for campamento households was 50.0%, positive predictive value for campamento residence was 12.3%, and negative predictive value was 99.0%. The fully labelled confusion matrix, with cell counts, is reported in Table A2. The low positive predictive value is a direct consequence of the outcome's rarity (approximately 1.9% prevalence in the test set) rather than an indication of poor model discrimination, and is consistent with the known behaviour of threshold-adjusted classifiers applied to rare-event data (King and Zeng 2001).

5.3. Robustness

Re-estimating the model with CASEN's regional expansion factor (expr) via svyglm() produced odds ratios consistent with the unweighted specification for the key predictors of interest (e.g., non-Latin American nationality: OR = 2.08 weighted vs. 2.09 unweighted; self-employment: OR = 1.40 weighted vs. 1.49 unweighted), supporting the claim that the reported associations hold under nationally representative weighting rather than reflecting an artefact of the unweighted sample composition. Variance inflation factors for

all covariates in the final model were below 2.3 ($GVIF^{(1/2\cdot df)}$), indicating no problematic multicollinearity.

6. Discussion

The regression identifies strong associations between labour-market position, foreign nationality, and residence in informal settlements; these findings are compatible with the interpretation that labour- and migration-related barriers contribute to housing exclusion, although the cross-sectional design does not establish the causal mechanisms. The associations reported above are interpreted in two registers: empirical claims are stated as probabilistic associations conditional on the model; the Lefebvrian reading that follows is an interpretive framework applied to those associations, not a claim tested by the regression. While TECHO-Chile's registers had already documented the scale of growth within campamentos, this model puts numbers on the correlates behind that growth. Labour precariousness and international migration rank among the characteristics most strongly associated with informal residence in the model, and the significant interaction between occupational category and nationality indicates that the two axes overlap.

Self-employment is associated with higher odds of residing in a campamento relative to formal public-sector employment. This effect, while smaller in magnitude than in an earlier working specification that used a misspecified informality proxy, is substantively meaningful and theoretically consistent with the literature: in Chile, formal employment operates as the practical gateway to the housing system, and subsidies, mortgages, and formal tenancy agreements may depend in practice on documented and stable income, depending on the programme or market segment (Section 3). Without a documented and reasonably stable income, a household simply cannot demonstrate the "institutional legality" demanded by the current subsidy architecture. Housing exclusion and labour market exclusion move together, and their overlap becomes a substantial barrier to belonging.

This helps explain why campamentos persist under a regime that demonstrably reduced the quantitative housing deficit in previous decades. The evidence suggests that the subsidy model was built around a specificised type of "ideal" beneficiary: households capable of documenting income, accumulating savings over years of deferred consumption, and maintaining a legal status before the state throughout protracted application periods. Many households simply cannot meet these criteria. As Hidalgo Dattwyler (2007, 2019) has argued, the model displaced precariousness to the urban periphery. The current growth of campamentos suggests that even this peripheral displacement, as a mechanism for absorption, has reached its limit.

International migration represents a second axis of exclusion, and the scale of recent change is dramatic. By 2024–2025, 47,391 migrant families were living in campamentos—39.3% of the national total. In regions such as Tarapacá and Antofagasta, migrants now constitute the majority of the settlement population. While this concentration partly reflects the geography of recent migratory flows, it also stems from the discriminatory structure of formal housing access in Chile. Discrimination in the rental market, residency requirements embedded in subsidy eligibility, and documentation barriers that filter migrants out of formal channels are documented barriers (López-Morales et al. 2018), consistent with exclusionary mechanisms that disproportionately concentrate migrants in informal settlements. The significant interaction between occupational category and nationality (H3) suggests that these two axes appear to overlap for some occupational groups, a pattern consistent with the intersectional overlap between migration status and labour-market position raised in peer review.

The socio-economic gradient reinforces this reading. Every stratum above 'E' shows a reduced probability of residing in a campamento. There is a persistent gap here: a

significant segment of the Chilean population earns too little for the private market and too irregularly for effective access to subsidies. These households inhabit an institutional "no-man's-land"—excluded from mortgage financing and poorly served by public programmes in equal measure. The likely outcomes under these constraints are overcrowding, precarious rental conditions, peripheral displacement, or residence in campamentos.

Regional heterogeneity, confirmed statistically by the categorical specification (H4), expresses this same problem in territorial terms. The growth of informal settlements concentrates where housing markets are under the greatest pressure, where governance capacity is thinnest, and where formal provision has failed to absorb low-income demand. These city-level patterns are drawn from TECHO-Chile's aggregate register (Section 3); the regression estimates region-level coefficients (Table 2, Table A1) but does not provide city-specific estimates within the regions. In these cities, the conflict between land treated as a speculative asset and land understood as a place of refuge and belonging is particularly acute.

Returning to the theoretical framework of Section 2, these findings revisit the "crisis of those with a roof" (los con techo) identified by Rodríguez and Sugranyes (2004). The Chilean model provided a roof for many while simultaneously reproducing distance, isolation, and exclusion from urban and civic life—a condition Hidalgo Dattwyler (2007) conceptualised as the "State-led precariopolis" (precariópolis estatal). Read through Lefebvre's lens, campamentos may be interpreted as the spaces through which the model absorbs the population it cannot integrate—a form of spatially constituted "waiting list" within the territory; this is a theoretical interpretation of the associations reported here, not a conclusion established by the regression. Chilean housing policy has offered something far narrower than Lefebvre's right to the city: debt-encumbered property for some, peripheral relegation for others, and expanding informality for those excluded from both paths. The evidence raises a fundamental question: can a housing system organised around formal employment, mortgage logic, and state subsidiary action ever truly guarantee both housing as a right and integration as a lived reality? On the evidence assembled here, its current institutional design constrains that possibility.

7. Conclusions

Residence in informal settlements in Chile is associated with labour market position and foreign nationality—two characteristics that lie at the heart of constrained immigrant integration. The logistic regression of 2022 CASEN data, considered alongside TECHO-Chile's aggregate temporal registers, indicates that self-employment and foreign nationality are among the strongest observed correlates of campamento residence, with significant regional heterogeneity and a modest, jointly significant interaction between occupational category and nationality, whose specific contrasts the data do not resolve. These are precisely the conditions that Chile's market-oriented housing model is least equipped to address. The concurrent acceleration of settlement growth documented by TECHO-Chile (2024) is consistent with reading this growth as a structural dynamic associated with the design of the country's housing and labour institutions, with direct consequences for the integration prospects of newcomers.

The contribution of this work to the literature on immigrant integration and urban informality in the Global South is threefold: first, in the empirically robust identification of campamento correlates using nationally representative data, confirmed through survey-weighted estimation; second, in linking individual-level survey evidence with aggregate temporal trends; and third, in situating the Chilean experience within broader debates on labour precariousness, migration governance, and the structural limits of demand-side housing policy as an integration mechanism.

7.1. Implications for Integration Policy and Practice

The following recommendations are normative, evidence-informed proposals, informed by the associations reported above and by the wider literature; the regression does not by itself evaluate their effectiveness. Each is specified in terms of its instrument, target population, responsible institution, evidentiary basis, and implementation constraint.

First, regarding subsidy eligibility: the instrument is the modification of income verification rules within Decreto Supremo N° 49; the target population is self-employed and informally employed workers; the responsible institution is MINVU; the evidentiary basis is the significant association between self-employment and campamento residence (OR = 1.49); the implementation constraint is the administrative difficulty of verifying non-standard income, though this complements rather than substitutes structural labour-formalisation policy. Accepting non-standard work records and implementing income-averaging mechanisms are crucial to meet SDG 8.3 (Decent Work and Economic Growth).

Second, regarding residency thresholds: the instrument is the elimination of the Certificado de Permanencia Definitiva requirement for housing subsidies; the target population is international migrants; the responsible institution is MINVU/Departamento de Extranjería; the evidentiary basis is the elevated odds for foreign nationals (OR = 2.06 to 2.09); the constraint is political resistance. Aligning with SDGs 10.7 (Reduced Inequalities) and 11.1 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) necessitates extending eligibility to all regular residents (defined legally as holders of permanent or temporary residence under Ley 21.325) and enforcing anti-discrimination measures in private rental markets.

Third, regarding settlement heterogeneity: the instrument is the application of the TECHO-Chile and Déficit Cero (2024) typologies for differentiated interventions; the target population is specific campamento profiles; the responsible institutions are regional SEREMIs and municipalities; the evidentiary basis is the documented diversity of settlement drivers, reinforced by the confirmed regional heterogeneity in the regression (H4); the constraint is the fragmentation of municipal capacities. Interventions must be calibrated to the specific drivers of each settlement rather than relying on uniform relocation strategies.

Fourth, regarding interim infrastructure: the instrument is the provision of basic water, sanitation, and electricity in situ; the target population is current campamento residents; the responsible institutions are municipalities and utility companies; the evidentiary basis is the national deficit of 650,000 units, which precludes immediate formal absorption; the constraint is tenure security and legal frameworks. Providing interim infrastructure prevents public health crises and preserves vital social and employment networks that underpin integration. Incremental urban integration should be viewed as a legitimate policy trajectory (Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo 2014).

Finally, regarding governance: the instrument is the decentralisation of housing and integration policy funding; the target population is residents of intermediate cities and regions with the highest regional coefficients (e.g., Antofagasta, Viña del Mar); the responsible institutions are Gobiernos Regionales (GOREs); the evidentiary basis is the statistically confirmed territorial concentration of settlement growth; the constraint is the need for equalisation mechanisms to prevent regional disparities. Regional authorities require the funding and autonomy needed to address the fragmented governance that ECLAC (Rodríguez and Oviedo 2001) identifies as a persistent barrier to effective provision.

7.2. Limitations

Several limitations qualify the conclusions that can be drawn, distinguished by whether they affect causal inference or prediction.

Causal inference: the cross-sectional design means the reported odds ratios are associations conditional on included covariates, not causal effects; labour informality, housing

exclusion, and migration status may reinforce one another over time in ways this design cannot disentangle; selection into informal employment and into campamento residence, and unobserved confounding (discrimination experiences, social networks, local housing prices and supply conditions, household composition, migration trajectories), may bias coefficients; foreign nationality serves as a proxy for migration status, since CASEN records neither legal residence status nor duration of residence; nationality categories may conceal heterogeneity across migrant groups (refugee versus labour-migration pathways, legal status differences, length of residence cannot be disaggregated with the variables available); gender, household composition, and other intersecting axes of vulnerability are not analysed here and represent a priority for future intersectional research; and the five-year internal-migration window may miss short-term dynamics.

Measurement and specification: missing values reflecting genuine skip patterns (migration origin, educational attainment) were coded as an explicit "not applicable" category rather than merged with the reference level, while missing values with trivial genuine missingness rates were recoded to zero, following the survey's treatment of non-applicable items; survey-weighted estimation using CASEN's regional expansion factor was conducted as a robustness check and produced results consistent with the unweighted specification, though full complex-sample variance estimation (incorporating strata and primary sampling units) was not implemented; variance inflation factors indicated no problematic collinearity among covariates; region was modelled as a categorical factor with confirmed joint significance; and housing-price and supply conditions remain unobserved.

Prediction: the low prevalence of the outcome (2.07%) limits positive predictive value even after threshold adjustment (12.3% at the 0.05 threshold); the threshold adjustment is a classification decision, not a bias correction, and bias-reduced estimators (e.g., Firth's penalised likelihood) were not applied; and entry into, persistence in, or exit from a campamento cannot be observed.

Finally, TECHO-Chile's registers are successive aggregate counts with changing methodology across editions, so temporal comparisons are indicative rather than exact, and no direct measures of housing prices, discrimination, or subsidy applications and rejections are available. Quantitative models cannot capture residents' lived experiences or micro-level decision-making, necessitating complementary ethnographic research on integration trajectories (Hosseini et al. 2023; Vergara-Perucich and Arias-Loyola 2021). These limitations define the boundary within which the associations reported here are interpreted and set a concrete agenda for future research.

Future research should complement this cross-sectional quantitative approach with longitudinal panel methods capable of establishing causal direction, with qualitative fieldwork to capture the lived experiences of residents and the micro-level decision-making processes through which households navigate structural exclusion and pursue—or are denied—integration, and with an explicitly intersectional framework incorporating gender and household composition. The typological differentiation of campamentos proposed by TECHO-Chile and Déficit Cero (2024) also opens a research agenda on settlement heterogeneity that this analysis, by nature of working with aggregate survey data, cannot pursue.

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Institutional Review Board Statement: This study relies exclusively on secondary, de-identified microdata from the 2022 CASEN survey (Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional), a publicly available national survey administered by the Chilean Ministry of Social Development and Family, which does not require additional institutional review for secondary analysis.

Informed Consent Statement: This study did not involve direct contact with human participants; it relies exclusively on anonymised secondary data from the publicly available 2022 CASEN survey.

Data Availability Statement: The CASEN 2022 dataset is publicly available from the Chilean Ministry of Social Development and Family Observatorio Social (http://observatorio.ministeriodesarrollosocial.gob.cl, accessed on 23 August 2026). TECHO-Chile settlement registers are publicly available at https://www.techo.org/chile/ (accessed on 23 August 2026).

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Appendix A

Table A1. Region coefficients.

Region	OR	95% CI	*p*	Sig
Metropolitana (ref.)	1.00 (ref.)	—	—	
Tarapacá	2.07	1.69–2.53	$p < 0.001$	***
Antofagasta	4.69	3.94–5.57	$p < 0.001$	***
Atacama	3.38	2.83–4.02	$p < 0.001$	***
Coquimbo	0.35	0.24–0.51	$p < 0.001$	***
Valparaíso	1.91	1.61–2.27	$p < 0.001$	***
O'Higgins	0.89	0.71–1.11	0.309	
Maule	0.14	0.09–0.22	$p < 0.001$	***
Biobío	0.97	0.80–1.17	0.732	
La Araucanía	0.97	0.79–1.19	0.781	
Los Lagos	1.38	1.12–1.70	0.003	**
Aysén	1.15	0.80–1.66	0.454	
Magallanes	0.21	0.11–0.44	$p < 0.001$	***
Los Ríos	1.23	0.98–1.55	0.069	
Arica y Parinacota	2.12	1.73–2.59	$p < 0.001$	***
Ñuble	0.28	0.19–0.40	$p < 0.001$	***

Note: Reference category: Región Metropolitana de Santiago. Significance: *** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$. Joint likelihood ratio test for region: Δdeviance = 1148.6, df = 15, $p < 0.001$.

Table A2. Confusion matrix for the logistic regression model, test set (classification threshold = 0.05).

	Actual: Campamento	Actual: Non-Campamento	Total	
Predicted: campamento	384	2738	3122	PPV = 12.3%
Predicted: non-campamento	384	36,940	37,324	NPV = 99.0%
Total	768	39,678	40,446	
Class recall	50.0%	93.1%		Balanced accuracy = 71.6%

Note: Test set (n = 40,446); classification threshold = 0.05; prevalence of campamento residence = 1.9%. The positive class reported here is campamento residence. Because caret's confusionMatrix() assigns the positive class by default to the majority category, all metrics are reported disaggregated by class to avoid ambiguity. PPV = positive predictive value; NPV = negative predictive value.

Notes

[1] Under Decreto Supremo N° 49 (Ministerio de Vivienda y Urbanismo 2011), regulating the Fondo Solidario de Elección de Vivienda (Solidarity Fund for Housing Choice), foreign applicants must present a Certificado de Permanencia Definitiva (Permanent Residency Certificate), and all applicants must be registered in the Registro Social de Hogares (Social Household Registry), Chile's means-tested socio-economic registry whose eligibility assessment requires verifiable income records.

[2] CASEN (Encuesta de Caracterización Socioeconómica Nacional/National Socioeconomic Characterisation Survey) is Chile's principal household survey, administered by the Ministerio de Desarrollo Social y Familia.

[3] NSE (nivel socioeconómico) refers to Chile's standard household socio-economic stratification, constructed in CASEN from the educational attainment and occupational category of the household head following the ESOMAR model adapted for the Chilean market-research context (Adimark GfK 2010). The scale orders households into six aggregate strata, from highest to lowest socio-economic standing: ABC1 (upper and upper-middle groups, conventionally aggregating levels A, B and C1), C2 (middle), C3 (lower-middle), D (working class) and E (households in situations of extreme vulnerability), with E serving as the reference category in Table 2. Because the classification rests on the head's education and occupation rather than directly on income, it captures durable socio-economic position and partially overlaps with—but is not reducible to—the income deciles reported separately in the same model.

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